Chapter Thirteen

The Almohads in Spain

Between 1147 and 1177, the Almohads destroy the Almoravids but fail to capture the Spanish peninsula

By 1147, Alfonso VII of León-Castile had pushed the southern front of Christian conquest more than halfway through the old Almoravid lands. In that same year, Alfonso I of Portugal captured Lisbon from its Muslim inhabitants, shoring up his claim of a royal title. And in the same year, the Almoravids fell. The Almohads stormed Marrakesh, under al-Mu'min's direction, and brought the weakened Almoravid rule to an end.[1]

The remnants of the Almoravid empire lingered on in Spain, cut loose from its roots. The city of Granada, now independent of Marrakesh, remained in Muslim hands; but without direction from Africa, it began to chart its own political course, making overtures of alliance to Alfonso VII himself. The cities of Valencia and Murcia formed a mini-kingdom ruled by Ibn Mardanish; he also decided to make peace with the Christian king of León-Castile, agreeing to become a vassal of Alfonso VII in exchange for peace.[2]

But this independence was short-lived. "When all the provinces of Morocco were submissive to al-Mu'min," the historian al-Marrakushi tells us, "he turned his armies to the eastern areas of North Africa, and then towards Spain." In 1155, Granada was forced to surrender to Almohad armies and acknowledge al-Mu'min's lordship. Two years later, the Almohads had